



ETHAN SWOPE Associated Press

SUMMIT FIRE GROWS

Trees are engulfed in Llano, Calif., on Friday. The wildfire expanded to more than 2,600 acres and was 0% contained as of Saturday afternoon, spurring evacuations amid a searing heat wave. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

Federal rollback of law imperils wildlife

Reduced habitat protections increase risk for state's 300 endangered species.

By JACK FLEMING

The Trump administration finalized a rollback of the Endangered Species Act on Friday, paving the way for drilling, mining and other human development across protected wildlife habitats.

The move redefines “harm” under the Endangered Species Act, the landmark conservation law that protects threatened and endangered plants and animals. For years, “harm” meant actions that injure or kill wildlife, as well as actions that destroy protected habitats.

Under the new rule, destroying those habitats is no longer illegal.

The decision aligns with the Trump administration's effort to slash regulations in the name of economic growth. Interior Secretary Doug Burgum, whose department finalized the move, said the prior definition of harm “interfered with private property rights” and “turned routine activity into a regulatory trap.”

Environmental groups called the decision a disaster, saying it puts protected species on a path to extinction.

The move seems especially poised to hit California, the most biodiverse state in the country, where more than 6,700 species are spread across mountains, forests, deserts and oceans. Of the roughly 2,300 species protected by the Endangered Species Act, nearly 300 are found in California.

These species include amphibians such as tiger salamanders and Yosemite toads; birds such as California condors and northern spotted owls; fish such as Little Kern golden trout and Santa Ana suckers; insects such as Franklin's bumble bees and Mission blue butterflies; mammals such as gray wolves and Santa

[See **Wildlife**, A7]

Cowboys, toxic trash and a race for plaintiffs

Some locals sour on lawyers in lucrative landfill cases

By REBECCA ELLIS

Val Verde is a place with few strangers.

Forty miles northwest of downtown Los Angeles, the tiny foothill community of 3,000 has one main road, spotty cell service and a lone local market.

Yet nobody could remember ever seeing the man in a cowboy hat before 2024, when he was spotted talking

to residents about lawsuits against the local dump.

At the time, the neighboring Chiquita Canyon landfill had never smelled worse. For more than a year, an uncontrolled fire had burned in the bowels of the dump, broiling old garbage and sending nauseating fumes into nearby homes.

Oshea Orchid, a local

lawyer, filed the first class-action lawsuit in 2023 against the operators of the county's second-largest landfill, alleging the fumes were sickening her neighbors, causing headaches and heart palpitations.

For months, she said, she'd been the only lawyer taking on the cases. But as

[See **Lawyers**, A10]



BEN DITTO For The Times

THERMALS in the Owens Valley are to flight what big waves are to surfing.

COLUMN ONE

Like dancing in the sky

Paragliders soar over California, where its world-famous conditions are among the riskiest

By Jack Dolan | REPORTING FROM OWENS VALLEY, CALIF.

Barry Smith was soaring at 18,000 feet, kept aloft by a flimsy nylon wing, when a crucial piece of equipment malfunctioned.

Without his portable oxygen system, he became clumsy and confused, “a little hypoxic,” he said, and plunged toward the 14,000-foot summit of White Mountain Peak.

As his head cleared and he realized he was too low to glide to the safety of the nearby valley, he started searching, desperately, for a landing spot on the steep, barren mountainside.

“I cursed the air, I cursed the mountain, I cursed myself,” Smith said.

Paragliding is an extreme sport no matter where it's done. But in the Owens

Valley, a strip of high desert sandwiched between the Sierra Nevada and the White Mountains, the heat and unique topography create towering, “rowdy” summer thermals — columns of warm, rising air — that rocket paragliders to altitudes higher than most small airplanes can fly.

Those thermals are to free flight what legendary waves like Mavericks and Jaws are to surfing: big, terrifying and, to a certain type of person, hopelessly addictive.

The Owens Valley, about 200 miles north of Los Angeles, is one of “the most powered-up and powerful places to fly on the planet,” said Gavin McClurg, an

[See **Paragliding**, A16]

Assassinations make Trump a target of Iran

Agencies tracking possible plots against the president say evidence is growing.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Shortly before President Trump ended a ceasefire with Iran last week, Israeli officials presented his team with intelligence indicating Tehran was hatching new plots to kill him.

It was not the first such warning. U.S. law enforcement and intelligence agencies have tracked evidence for years of Iranian efforts to target the president, with signals only increasing since the start of the war.

Their desire to target Trump and his top aides began six years ago, just outside Baghdad International Airport, when the president ordered a drone strike that killed Iran's most powerful general. The assassination of Qassem Soleimani brought the two countries to

Leaders' mutual threats escalate

New peril for talks after U.S. and Iran exchange words and launch more strikes. **WORLD, A3**

the brink of war.

Yet even as full-scale war was averted, top Iranian officials vowed revenge for the strike, authorizing attempts on the lives not just of the president, but of his secretary of State and national security advisor, among others, even after they had left office.

Now, calls for revenge have reached a sharper pitch in Tehran, after a joint U.S.-Israeli operation killed Iran's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, at the start of the war in February.

At Khamenei's funeral ceremonies last week, red flags of vengeance flew throughout the capital as protesters explicitly called on their government to “kill Trump.”

[See **Assassinations**, A7]

Gas prices, crude oil costs diverge

With global conflicts, experts say consumers should brace for more pain at the pump.

By WILL KUBZANSKY, YONGCHANG CHIN AND JACK FARCHY

Prices for gasoline, diesel and jet fuel are rising again even as that for crude oil eases, a rare divergence that's swelling costs for peak-season travelers and threatening to undermine President Trump's pledge to quash inflation ahead of the midterm elections.

The gap between the cost of some refined products and raw crude is at a record in the U.S. and other regions

even as global oil benchmarks have all but erased the spike driven by the Iran war. Some analysts warn that consumers need to brace for more pain at the pump as a Russian export ban stemming from the war with Ukraine and renewed fighting in the Middle East squeeze supplies.

“Refineries are already running at very high utilization rates,” said Jamie Torrance, who runs diesel and jet fuel trading at Trafigura Group, one of the largest global oil merchants. “Yet inventories are still drawing.”

For governments and central banks, fuel markets are a painful reminder of the inflationary fallout from Trump's decision to go to war with Iran and failure to

[See **Fuel**, A7]

AIRLINES: Carriers spent \$6.66 billion to fill tanks in May, an 84% increase from a year ago. **BUSINESS, A11**



DAN MULLAN Getty Images

A VAR, or video assistant referee, review led to a tying goal by Croatia being nullified in the World Cup.

Does perfection hurt the World Cup's spirit?

By KEVIN BAXTER

Croatia's World Cup was seconds away from being over and Portugal was seconds away from the round of 16 when Ivan Perisic sent a long, desperate cross into the penalty area. The ball bounced off bodies like a pinball before magically, unbelievably, caroming into the net.

Goooooooooooooooo!!!!
Fate had given Croatia a

reprieve.

But as pandemonium broke out in the stands and on the pitch, Norwegian referee Espen Eskas stood in the middle of the celebration in Toronto, hand to his ear, listening to a voice half a continent away in Dallas.

The voice recommended a review, via the video assistant referee, or VAR.

So Eskas trotted over to a TV monitor, watched a video replay over and over again,

[See **World Cup**, A9]

Journalists get DOJ subpoenas

Action against New York Times reporters heightens concerns over growing threat to press freedom. **NATION, A6**

Rep. Khanna says he was detained

Fremont lawmaker says armed Israeli settlers blocked and held visiting delegation in the West Bank. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

The yummy dog days of summer

From classic franks to perros calientes, these are the best links that L.A. has to tantalize the taste buds. **WEEKEND, L6**

Weather
Sunny spells.
L.A. Basin: 83/65. **B8**



THIS IS US: Seven reasons why U.S. men's national team keeps crashing out in the World Cup. **SPORTS, D1**